

Where Do You Want to Be in Five Years?

How about 10 years?

(Take 30 seconds to think about this.)

That Question Has Multiple Dimensions

Dimension	Questions
Career	Role? Employer type? Skills?
Location	City/region? Near family?
Life	Family? Home ownership? Financial goals?
Work-life	Hours/week? Remote?

Your employer choice affects *all of these* — often more than you realize.

Today's Roadmap

1. **Employer Landscape:** Seven types of organizations
2. **Mobility:** Geographic, career, and upward mobility
3. **Alternative Paths:** IT departments and medium employers
4. **Promotions vs. Switching:** The stay-or-jump calculus
5. **Decision Frameworks:** Mapping your values to opportunities
6. **Data & Tools:** Salary benchmarks and resources

Part 1: Employer Types

Overview: Seven Employer Categories

Type	Compensation	Stability	Learning	WLB
Startups	Low-Med (equity)	Low	Very High	Low
Big Tech	High	Medium	Med-High	Med
IT Departments	Med-Low	High	Medium	Med-High
Mid-Size	Med-High	Medium	High	Med
Government	Medium	High	Medium	High
Nonprofits	Low-Med	Med-Low	Medium	Med-High
Consulting	High	Medium	Very High	Low

Overview: Mobility by Employer Type

Type	Geographic	Career	Upward
Startups	Low (hubs)	High (broad skills)	Fast
Big Tech	Medium	High (brand)	Slow
IT Departments	High (everywhere)	Low-Med	Fast
Mid-Size	Medium	Medium	Med-Fast
Government	Medium	Low-Med (clearance)	Slow
Nonprofits	Low (DC/NYC)	Low	Slow
Consulting	Medium	High (network)	Fast

1. Startups & Small Businesses

“Your code can literally keep the company alive next quarter — or make it the next unicorn.”

Characteristics: <50-500 employees, often pre-IPO or early-stage

Pros

- ▶ Massive ownership: deploy, support, talk to customers
- ▶ Fastest learning curve: full stack + DevOps + business in months
- ▶ Equity upside potential + flat culture, quick promotions

Cons

- ▶ Lower base pay + “always on” culture
- ▶ Company can fold overnight — high risk
- ▶ No formal training; chaotic tech decisions

Startups: The Numbers

Company Size	Base Salary	Equity
<10 employees	\$70k-100k	0.1-1.0%
10-50 employees	\$85k-120k	0.05-0.25%
50-500 employees	\$100k-140k	0.01-0.1%

Source: Levels.fyi, AngelList (2024-2025)

Fit: Risk-tolerant, learns by doing. **Outlook:** Equity payoff or pivot.

Mobility: Broad skills, no brand.

2. Big Tech & Fortune 500

“Prestige on the résumé opens every door... but you might spend six months in approval meetings before your PR merges.”

Characteristics: FAANG, FAANG-adjacent, banks, Fortune 500 tech divisions

Pros

- ▶ Highest total comp: \$120k-180k+ with structured career ladders
- ▶ Brand name opens doors + resources (cloud credits, conferences)
- ▶ Structured onboarding, mentorship, clear progression

Cons

- ▶ Heavy bureaucracy, politics, slow innovation pace
- ▶ Hyper-specialized roles; legacy code maintenance
- ▶ Layoff waves (2022-2024: 400k+ tech layoffs)

Big Tech: The Numbers

Company	Base	Stock	Bonus	Total
Google (L3)	\$145k	\$70k	\$25k	~\$240k
Amazon (L4)	\$130k	\$80k	\$0-50k	~\$180k
Microsoft	\$125k	\$40k	\$20k	~\$185k
Bank	\$110k	\$15k	\$30k	~\$155k

Source: Levels.fyi

Fit: Wants depth, stability + brand. **Outlook:** Senior/Staff, \$400k+.

Mobility: Brand opens doors.

Big Tech: Career Ladders

Typical Progression (Google-style)

Level	Title	Years	Total Comp
L3	Junior SWE	0-2	\$200-250k
L4	SWE	2-4	\$280-350k
L5	Senior SWE	4-7	\$350-500k
L6	Staff SWE	7-12	\$500-800k

Key insight: Promotions are *structured but slow*. L3→L4 typically 2 years; L4→L5 another 2-3 years.

3. Government Agencies

“While Big Tech is laying off thousands, government IT hiring is steady — and you get a pension.”

Characteristics: Federal, state, DoD, NASA, IRS, national labs

Pros

- ▶ Excellent work-life balance + very high job security
- ▶ Pensions + strong benefits + mission-driven work
- ▶ Modern tools in many agencies (AWS, Python, Kubernetes)

Cons

- ▶ Lower pay (20-40% below private sector)
- ▶ Slow hiring (background checks: 6-12 months)
- ▶ Bureaucracy and legacy systems (some still run COBOL!)

Government: The Numbers

Grade	Base	With Locality (+30%)
GS-7 (Entry)	\$45-58k	~\$60-75k
GS-9	\$55-71k	~\$72-92k
GS-11	\$67-87k	~\$87-113k
GS-12	\$80-104k	~\$104-135k
GS-13	\$95-124k	~\$124-161k

Plus: Pension (FERS), TSP matching, health benefits

Fit: Values stability, WLB. **Outlook:** GS-13/14, pension vesting.

Mobility: Clearance portable to defense.

Government: The Hidden Asset

Security Clearances = Career Accelerator

- ▶ Secret clearance: 2-4 month process
- ▶ Top Secret: 6-12 month process
- ▶ **Clearance holders earn 10-30% more** in defense contracting
- ▶ Clearance transfers to private sector (Lockheed, Raytheon, etc.)
- ▶ **Demand exceeds supply:** 1.4M clearance jobs unfilled (2024)

4. Nonprofits & NGOs

“Your code helps kids learn to read or saves endangered species instead of selling ads.”

Characteristics: Charities, NGOs, universities, foundations
(Code.org, Khan Academy, environmental orgs)

Pros

- ▶ Deep personal fulfillment and value alignment
- ▶ Passionate culture + broad roles (full-stack, data, impact)
- ▶ Often remote-friendly + better mental health

Cons

- ▶ Significantly lower pay (sometimes volunteer-level)
- ▶ Tight budgets = outdated tools, fewer career ladders
- ▶ Harder to jump to high-paying private sector later

Nonprofits: The Numbers

Organization Type	Base Salary
Small NGO	\$50k-75k
University/Research	\$70k-95k
Large Nonprofit	\$90k-130k
Tech-for-good	\$100k-140k

Source: Glassdoor, Idealist.org, Levels.fyi

Fit: Values meaning over money. **Outlook:** Mission-aligned career.

Mobility: Niche experience, harder to exit to private sector.

5. Consulting Firms

“You’ll see 5-10 different tech stacks and industries in your first two years — but you’ll also live out of a suitcase.”

Characteristics: Accenture, Deloitte, Big 4 tech consulting, boutique firms, ThoughtWorks

Pros

- ▶ Fastest skill ramp-up: variety of stacks and industries
- ▶ High pay + excellent training programs
- ▶ Networking gold: great stepping stone to product companies

Cons

- ▶ Billable-hour pressure + long hours + travel
- ▶ “You build it, you don’t own it” — less product ownership
- ▶ “Up or out” culture creates pressure

Consulting: The Numbers

Firm Type	Base	Bonus	Total
MBB (McKinsey)	\$110k	\$20-30k	\$130-140k
Big 4 (Deloitte)	\$85k	\$10-15k	\$95-100k
Accenture	\$80k	\$5-15k	\$85-95k
Boutique	\$90k	\$10-20k	\$100-110k

Fit: Loves variety, people-facing. **Outlook:** Partner track or exit to product. **Mobility:** High — network + breadth.

Consulting: The 2-Year Rule

Common Path: 1-3 years consulting → exit to Big Tech or startups

Why?

- ▶ Built breadth: “I’ve used React, Python, Go, and deployed on AWS, GCP, and Azure”
- ▶ Client exposure: worked with finance, healthcare, retail teams
- ▶ Networking: former clients become job leads
- ▶ Clear resume signal: “can handle client pressure”

Risk: Resume looks scattered if you stay too long without specializing

Part 2: Alternative Paths

Beyond Big Tech and Startups

Not every CS/IT grad works at a tech company — often a smart choice.

Many of the best career opportunities are in:

- ▶ **IT departments** of non-tech companies
- ▶ **Medium-sized employers** (500-5,000 employees)
- ▶ **Regional companies** outside major tech hubs

These paths are often **overlooked but undervalued.**

IT Departments: Where Are They?

Industries that hire IT/CS but aren't "tech companies":

Sector	Examples	Typical Roles
Healthcare	Hospital systems, insurers	EHR, infrastructure, data
Retail	Walmart, Target, Kroger	POS, inventory, logistics
Manufacturing	Auto, aerospace, consumer goods	ERP, plant systems, supply chain
Insurance	Carriers, regional insurers	Policy systems, claims, mainframes
Utilities	Power, water, telecom	SCADA, billing, smart grid
Logistics	FedEx, UPS, distributors	Warehouse, tracking, routing
Universities	Campus IT, research computing	LMS, infrastructure, support

IT Departments: Pros and Cons

Pros

- ▶ **Less competition** + geographic flexibility (jobs everywhere)
- ▶ **Stability** + “big fish in small pond” = faster path to leadership
- ▶ **Domain expertise**: healthcare IT, manufacturing ERP specialist

Cons

- ▶ **Lower pay**: 20-40% below Big Tech
- ▶ **Legacy systems**: COBOL, old Java, proprietary ERP
- ▶ **Skills transfer risk** + less prestige = harder to jump to “pure tech”

IT Departments: The Numbers

Sector	Entry	Mid	Senior
Healthcare IT	\$65-85k	\$85-120k	\$120-160k
Retail	\$70-90k	\$90-130k	\$130-170k
Manufacturing	\$65-80k	\$80-110k	\$110-150k
Insurance	\$65-85k	\$85-115k	\$115-155k
Utilities	\$70-90k	\$90-125k	\$125-165k
Universities	\$55-75k	\$70-95k	\$95-130k

Fit: Stability, location, domain interest. **Outlook:** IT Director/VP.

Mobility: High geographic, low to “pure tech”.

Medium-Sized Employers: The Sweet Spot

Definition: 500-5,000 employees

Examples: - Vertical SaaS companies (Procore, Toast, Veeva) -
Regional tech companies - Post-startup growth phase companies -
Mid-market consultancies - Subsidiaries of larger firms

Why they're overlooked: Not famous like FAANG, not “sexy” like startups

Why they're valuable: Best of both worlds

Medium-Sized Employers: Pros and Cons

Pros

- ▶ **Process without bureaucracy:** Enough structure, not blocked
- ▶ **Growth opportunities** + visibility (execs know your name)
- ▶ **Mentorship + breadth/depth** + reasonable hours

Cons

- ▶ **Less brand recognition:** Harder to explain on resume
- ▶ **Risk of stagnation** if growth slows + acquisition risk
- ▶ **Limited resources:** Not FAANG-level perks or budgets

Medium-Sized Employers: The Numbers

Company Stage	Entry	Mid	Senior
Series B-C (50-200)	\$100-130k	\$150-200k	\$200-300k
Growth (200-1000)	\$110-150k	\$170-250k	\$250-400k
Established (1k-5k)	\$120-160k	\$180-280k	\$280-450k
Pre-IPO late stage	\$130-180k	\$200-350k	\$350-550k

Fit: Wants balance. **Outlook:** Director/VP if company grew.

Mobility: Balanced — some brand, some breadth.

The “Big Fish in Small Pond” Strategy

Factor	Big Tech	IT/Mid-Size
Competition	High	Low
Time to senior	4-7 yr	2-5 yr
Time to leadership	7-12 yr	4-8 yr
Visibility	Low	High
Ownership	Narrow	Broad

Key insight: At a regional hospital, you might be the *only* person who understands the EHR integration. That's leverage.

Career Paths: Alternative Routes

Path A: Healthcare IT → Health Tech Leader

Hospital IT (3 yr) → Health tech startup (3 yr) → VP Engineering (yr 7)
→ CTO/Founder (yr 10+)

Path B: Manufacturing ERP → Specialized Consultant

Auto manufacturer IT (4 yr) → Big 4 consulting (3 yr) → Boutique ERP partner (yr 10)

Path C: Mid-Size SaaS → Founder

Growing SaaS (4 yr) → Lead engineer (2 yr) → Founder with network (yr 7)

When to Choose Alternative Paths

Choose IT Departments When:

- ▶ Geographic flexibility, family location, or lower COL matters
- ▶ You want “big fish in small pond” + faster leadership path
- ▶ Domain expertise appeals (healthcare, manufacturing, finance)

Choose Medium-Sized Employers When:

- ▶ You want balance: structure + agility + visibility
- ▶ Growth opportunities matter more than brand recognition
- ▶ Early career mentorship or mid-career faster promotion

The Mobility Trap

Path	Entry	Exit	Reason
Big Tech → anywhere	Hard	Easy	Brand opens doors
IT Dept → Big Tech	Easy	Hard	No brand + legacy skills
Nonprofit → Private	Easy	Hard	Lower comp, less brand
Startup → Big Tech	Easy	Medium	Must prove yourself
Consulting → Product	Medium	Medium	Need specialization

Ask yourself: Stepping stone or potential dead end?

Part 3: Promotions vs. Job Switching

The Salary Growth Reality

Internal Raises vs. External Offers

Source	Average Annual Raise
Internal merit raise	3-5%
Promotion raise	10-20%
External job switch	15-25%
Counter-offer (if you stay)	10-15%

Source: HBR, LinkedIn Salary Insights, Hired.com State of Software Engineers (2024)

Key insight: Switching jobs often yields 3-5x the raise of staying put.

Why Do Switchers Earn More?

1. **Market correction:** Your current company may undervalue you
2. **Negotiation leverage:** New employer competes for you
3. **Level inflation:** “Senior” at Company A $\neq$ “Senior” at Company B
4. **Sign-on bonuses:** \$10k-50k for switching
5. **Equity refresh:** New grant at current valuation

But... there are hidden costs

Hidden Costs of Job Switching

Cost	Impact
Unvested equity	Lost RSUs worth \$20k-100k+
Restart on relationships	Political capital resets to zero
Resume scrutiny	Multiple 1-year stints raise red flags
Learning curve	3-6 months to full productivity
401(k) vesting	May restart match clock
Promotion timing	Leave right before promotion?

Rule of thumb: After 2+ years, switching is usually net positive.
Under 18 months, proceed with caution.

Promotion Timelines by Employer Type

Employer Type	Time to First Promotion	Promotion Process
Big Tech	18-24 months	Structured, levels, committees
Startups	6-18 months (or never)	Ad-hoc, title inflation risk
Government	2-4 years	Seniority-based, structured
Nonprofits	1-3 years	Often informal, limited ladder
Consulting	2-3 years (or “up or out”)	Performance + billable hours

Big Tech: Predictable but slow **Startups:** Fast but unpredictable
Government: Slow but guaranteed (with tenure)

When to Stay

- ▶ On the cusp of promotion (within 6 months)
- ▶ Strong mentor relationship
- ▶ High-visibility project in progress
- ▶ Significant unvested equity cliff approaching
- ▶ Learning curve is still steep
- ▶ Team/company culture fits well

When to Jump

- ▶ Skills have plateaued (no growth in 6+ months)
- ▶ Toxic work environment
- ▶ Compensation significantly below market (15%+ gap)
- ▶ No clear path to next level
- ▶ Company instability or layoffs
- ▶ Better opportunity aligns with long-term goals

Career Phase Thinking

Early Career (0-3 years)

- ▶ Prioritize: **Learning > Compensation > Stability**
- ▶ Switching is lower risk; resume experimentation is expected
- ▶ Optimal: High-learning environments (startups, consulting, Big Tech teams)

Mid-Career (3-7 years)

- ▶ Prioritize: **Depth + Brand + Compensation**
- ▶ Switching still valuable, but be strategic
- ▶ Optimal: Building toward Senior/Staff level at respected company

Senior Career (7+ years)

- ▶ Prioritize: **Impact + Autonomy + Lifestyle**
- ▶ Switching costs increase (equity, relationships, family)
- ▶ Optimal: Choose employers aligned with long-term goals

The 2x2 Framework: Time × Opportunity

Time	High Growth	Low Growth
< 18 mo	Stay and learn	Jump
18-36 mo	Stay through promotion	Jump
36+ mo	Evaluate	Jump

Part 4: Decision Frameworks

Values Prioritization

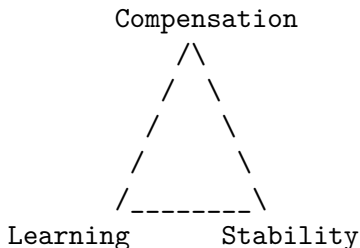
Rank your top 3 (from earlier):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Now map to employer types:

Top Value	Best Employer Fit
Compensation	Big Tech, Consulting
Work-life balance	Government, Nonprofits, IT Depts
Learning speed	Startups, Consulting, Mid-Size
Job security	Government, Big Tech, IT Depts
Social impact	Nonprofits, Government

The Trade-off Triangle



You can optimize for two, but rarely all three.

- ▶ Startups: High Learning, Low Stability
- ▶ Big Tech: High Compensation, High Stability
- ▶ Government: High Stability, Medium Learning
- ▶ Consulting: High Learning, High Compensation
- ▶ Nonprofits: High Stability (mission), Low Compensation
- ▶ IT Departments: High Stability, Low Compensation
- ▶ Mid-Size: Medium on all three — balanced

Risk Tolerance Assessment

Ask yourself:

1. Could I handle being laid off with 2 weeks notice?
2. Would I accept 50% of market salary for 0.5% equity?
3. Could I work 60+ hour weeks for 6 months?
4. Would I relocate for a better opportunity?
5. Am I comfortable with ambiguous career paths?

Scoring:

- ▶ 4-5 "Yes" → High risk tolerance → Startups, Consulting
- ▶ 2-3 "Yes" → Medium → Big Tech, Mid-size companies, IT Depts
- ▶ 0-1 "Yes" → Low → Government, Nonprofits

Scenario A: Maximize Compensation

1. Start at Big Tech (L3, \$200k)
2. 2 years → switch to competitor (L4, \$300k)
3. 2 years → switch to pre-IPO startup (Sr. Eng + equity)
4. 4 years → total comp: \$400k+ or equity payoff

Risk: Burnout, layoffs, resume fragmentation

Scenario B: Maximize Learning + Impact

1. Start at startup (wears many hats)
2. 2 years → join growing startup (lead engineer)
3. 2 years → join nonprofit or B-corp (senior role)
4. Build reputation, open source, conference talks

Risk: Lower lifetime earnings, less “brand” recognition

Scenario C: Maximize Stability + WLB

1. Start at government agency (GS-7, \$65k)
2. 4 years → GS-12 (\$120k)
3. 4 years → GS-14 (\$160k + pension)
4. Retire with pension + TSP

Risk: Slower growth, less wealth accumulation

Which Path Matches Your Vision?

Look back at your 5-10 year answer.

- ▶ Scenario A (compensation) → Is high salary your priority?
- ▶ Scenario B (learning + impact) → Is meaning more important than money?
- ▶ Scenario C (stability + WLB) → Is predictability what you want?

Your answer determines which path to target.

Decision Framework: Key Questions

Before accepting any offer, ask:

1. What will I learn in the first year?
2. What's the typical promotion timeline?
3. What's the equity vesting schedule?
4. What does my 5-year path look like?
5. What happens if the company struggles?
6. How does this align with my top values?

If you can't answer these clearly, you're not ready to decide.

Part 5: Data & Resources

Salary Benchmarks: 5-Year Projections

Software Engineer Career Paths (Total Comp)

Year	Startup	Big Tech	Mid-Size	IT Dept	Government	Non-profit
0	\$90k	\$200k	\$130k	\$75k	\$70k	\$75k
2	\$110k	\$280k	\$180k	\$95k	\$85k	\$85k
4	\$130k*	\$380k	\$250k	\$120k	\$110k	\$100k
5	\$150k*	\$450k	\$300k	\$135k	\$125k	\$110k

* Startup assumes company survives; equity value varies wildly

Source: Levels.fyi, BLS, author estimates

Switching vs. Staying: Data

After 5 years, two paths:

Path	Average Comp
Stayed at 1 company	\$180k
Switched twice (2-3 year intervals)	\$240k
Switched 4+ times (1-2 year intervals)	\$220k

Insight: Strategic switching (every 2-3 years) maximizes comp. Too many switches hurts.

Source: Hired.com State of Software Engineers (2024)

Resources for Job Seekers

Salary Data

- ▶ Levels.fyi — salary by company, level, location
- ▶ Glassdoor — company reviews + salaries
- ▶ Blind — anonymous tech worker discussions

Job Boards by Type

- ▶ Startups: AngelList, Y Combinator jobs
- ▶ Big Tech: Company careers pages
- ▶ Government: USAJobs.gov, State job portals
- ▶ Nonprofits: Idealist.org, TechJobsForGood.com
- ▶ Consulting: Company sites, LinkedIn

Resources: Career Strategy

Books

- ▶ *The Software Engineer's Guidebook* — growth paths and decision-making
- ▶ *Staff Engineer* — paths beyond senior
- ▶ *The Mom Test* — asking the right questions

Articles

- ▶ “Stay or Go?” — HBR on switching decisions
- ▶ “The Company You Keep” — how employer brand affects career

Communities

- ▶ Reddit r/cscareerquestions
- ▶ Blind (anonymous)
- ▶ LinkedIn career groups

Conclusion

Action Items

This week: Rank values, research 3 companies per category, check Levels.fyi

This month: Identify risk tolerance, map skills to roles, start networking

Long-term: Revisit priorities annually, track progression, build in reflection time

Key Takeaways

1. **The 5-10 year question is your north star** — use it to guide decisions
2. **Employer type determines most of your work life** before you interview
3. **Alternative paths (IT depts, mid-size)** are overlooked but offer real advantages
4. **Mobility matters** — some paths are easier to enter than exit
5. **Switching usually pays more** than staying — but has hidden costs
6. **Intentional choices beat default choices** — know what you're optimizing for

Your Turn

Where do you want to be in 5-10 years?

Now you have:

- ▶ A map of employer types and their trade-offs
- ▶ Understanding of mobility constraints and opportunities
- ▶ Tools to evaluate promotions vs. switching
- ▶ Frameworks to make intentional choices

Use them.